



DVD-ROM DRIVES

DVD-ROM drives are here to stay. Armed with complete backward compatibility for CD-ROM drives, enhanced functionality in terms of larger data storage and the fact that you can watch Dolby Digital movies on them, these entertainers are on everyone's wish list! A lot has changed over the past year with DVD-ROM drives—most importantly, the speeds and the price. Till recently, users dismissed DVD-ROM drives as an unnecessary expense. But due to the spread of DVD movies and the fact that their price has been plummeting for the past one year, DVD-ROM drives are now considered an essential upgrade from the CD-ROM drive. Even though there aren't too many applications made for the DVD, it still makes sense to invest in this drive as it warrants higher speeds and total compatibility with CD-ROM drives, especially if you are a movie buff.

Under the lens

When considering a DVD-ROM drive, there are a few parameters that you should consider. These are not very different from the things that you would examine when buying CD-ROM drives—the read data transfer speeds, access time and interface still need to be considered. Most 16x DVD-ROM drives available today boast of sequential read speeds in the range of 6 MBps to 8 MBps. The access times of these drives range from 70 ms to 150 ms—the lower, the better. Don't buy a drive that is rated to run lower than this speed and stay far away from sub-16x DVD-ROM drives. Drives with access times lower than 70 ms will be slow when you work with CD and DVD-based applications, especially if those applications cause the drive to read in a random fashion.

As with any optical drive, make use of its DMA (Direct Memory Access) support by enabling the DMA mode from your operating system and from the BIOS. Your machine may show symptoms of degraded performance during DVD playback if you run the drive in PIO (Programmed Input/Output) mode.

Most drives are based on the ATA/33 standard though there are a few that support ATA/66. However, this standard isn't very crucial, as optical drives never reach even half the bandwidth offered by this interface. Finally, look for a drive that has a large buffer—512 KB is standard but some drives are built around 256 KB buffers—stay away from these. Apart from performance, also consider support for as many standards as possible to ensure that it can be used with a vast spread of media.

Nominees

Name	Contacts	Comments
Liteon LTD-165H	Mediatech India, Ph: 022-56396696	A very commendable performer, this 16x DVD-ROM drive offered very good performance and is also very competitively priced.
Pioneer DVD-106S/2	Mnemonic Systems, Ph: 022-28010871	With its slot-in interface, the Pioneer DVD-ROM drive boasted very good performance with excellent build quality.

Also, it is always advisable to go for a DVD drive package that comes with a good bundle of software which can be used for applications such as DVD playback applications. Since the use of DVD-ROM drives is for DVD movie playback, go for a drive that bundles an application such as PowerDVD or VobSub. Some of the less popular drives do have an advantage of being better-priced, but they might not have a corporate backing that features things like regular updates to the BIOS to take care of possible bugs or adding functional features for better performance.

Finally, if you create a lot of MP3 files, you should see if the drive supports Digital Audio Extraction (DAE). If it does, see that it is able to do so at speeds of at least 12x. If not, you are looking for performance.

There are standards like DVD-R, DVD-RW, DVD-R, DVD+R and all of them are not necessarily supported by all drives—if a drive does not support a particular standard, you will not be able to read from that media. Though most users stick to DVD disks, it will come a time when other DVD media formats will be available. Therefore, it makes sense to go for a drive that supports as many standards as possible.

Finally, make sure that the drive is compatible with all the DVDs available in your region. Most DVD drives are region locked, that is, they can only play DVD movies from regions that match their own. You can change the region code a maximum of five times, after which it stays locked to the last setting.

And the award goes to...

The drive that really shone in performance this year was the BenQ DVP-1648A 16x DVD drive. With blistering performance in the read tests and an excellent access time, topped off with crunched through all the applications it was subjected to, icing on the cake is that it is also one of the most affordable drives in the market.



BenQ DVP-1648A

BenQ India Pvt Ltd,
Ph: 022-25705230

The verdict: This 16x DVD drive

performed brilliantly in the read tests over various types of data, making it the best suited to applications needing frequent CD and DVD access

